

Interpreting the Quran

The Classical View متقدمين كائنه نظر

Classical scholars are divided in two broad categories as far as their principles of interpreting the *Qur'an* are concerned:

1. The *Tafsir bi'l Riwayah* School
2. The *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay* School

The *Tafsir bi'l Riwayah* (تفسير بالرواية) School

- Methodology:** *Tafsir bi'l Riwayah* means to interpret the *Qur'an* in the light of the *Manqulat* منقولات (knowledge transmitted from our predecessors).
1. Quran قرآن
 2. Sunnah سنت
 3. Companions (rta) صحابه كرام
 4. Successors (Tabi'un) تابعين

Three Approaches in Quran Interpretation:

1. The Makkan Group

According to many scholars, this group of *Mufasssirun* from among the *Tabi'un* are considered the most knowledgeable in *Tafsir*, because they learnt about it from *Ibn 'Abbas* (rta). They are many in number, and among the best known out of many others are *Mujahid* (d: 104 AH), *'Ata* (d: 114 AH) and *'Ikrimah* (d: 107 AH).

2. The Madinan Group

The *Mufasssirun* among the *Tabi'un* from *Madiyah* had many Companions as their teachers, among the best known being *'Ubai Ibn Ka'ab* (rta). The following are some of the well-known *Qur'an* exegetes among them: *Muhammad Ibn Ka'ab Qurdi* (d: 117 AH), *Abu'l 'Aliyah* (d: 90AH) and *Zayd Ibn Aslam* (d: 130 AH).

3. The Iraqi Group

There were also many *Mufasssirun* among the *Tabi'un* in Iraq. Their principal teacher was *Ibn Mas'ud* (rta). Their main centers were *Basrah* and *Kufah*. The best known among them are *Hasan Basri* (d: 121 AH), *Masruq Ibn Ajda'* (d: 63 AH) and *Ibrahim Nakha'i* (d: 95AH).

Historical Development

a. The 1st Period: Oral Transmission (up to 250 AH) The first period begins from the time when the Prophet (sws) was alive. In this period, various explanations of a verse were orally transmitted by various scholars among the Companions. They transmitted these explanations not only from the Prophet (sws) but also from one another. Later, the *Tabi'un* (Successors) took up this task. They also narrated explanations of *Qur'anic* verses from the Companions as well as from among their contemporaries. Personal reasoning from the Companions and Successors was, in general, only resorted to when absolutely necessary.

b. The 2nd Period: Chapters in *Hadith* Books (250 AH - 300 AH) The second period is the era of the late Successors, and the generation after them. During this time, *Hadith* literature had begun to be compiled, the *Tafsir* narrations therefore become a part of *Hadith* works. Also during this time, the various *Ahadith* of the Prophet (sws) and narrations from different Companions began to be compiled, whereas in the first period, these narrations were typically limited to a specific area. In this period, *Hadith* Books were compiled and almost each of them carried chapter called *Kitabu'l-Tafsir*.

c. The 3rd Period: Independent *Tafsir* Works (300-400 AH onwards)

This period begins from the end of the *Umayyid* period. It saw the rise of independent *Tafsir* works, based on the *Hadith* works of the previous generation, and thus *Tafsir* became an independent science among the Islamic sciences. This stage also produced the first complete *Qur'anic Tafsirs*, whose commentary was not limited to only those verses concerning which narrations existed from previous generations. However, during this stage, the primary sources of *Tafsir* still remained narrations from the previous generation.

d. The 4th Period: Specialized *Tafsir* Works (400 AH onwards)

The fourth and final period of the history of *Tafsir*, which has lasted from the fourth century of the *hijrah* until today, saw the culmination of the science of *Tafsir*, and the emergence of various categories of *Tafsir*, such as *Tafsir* based on narrations, on personal reasoning, topic-wise interpretation, polemical interpretation, and jurisprudential interpretation.

Important Tafsirs

Jami'u'l-Bayan 'an Tawil Aay al-Qur'an جامع البيان عن التاويل القرآن (The Comprehensive Explanation of the Interpretation of the Verses of the *Qur'an*), by *Muhammad Ibn Jarir Tabari* (224-310 AH) is one of the earliest and greatest *Tafsirs* in existence, and is considered the first reference to turn to among all the works of *Tafsir*. *Tabari* compiled in this *Tafsir* many narratives from the Prophet (sws), the Companions, the Successors and those after them concerning the interpretation of the verses and phrases of the *Qur'an*. Typically, *Tabari* quotes a verse of the *Qur'an*, and then states, 'The various narratives concerning the interpretation of such-and such...' and then proceeds to quote up to a dozen narratives from the past authorities. After quoting the various narrations on a verse, he usually gives the opinion that he thinks is the strongest one, with his evidence. At times, he also discusses the various *Qira'at* of a verse, quotes lines of classical poetry to substantiate the meaning of an obscure word, delves into a grammatical analysis of a verse and uses his own reasoning. One of the unique features of this *Tafsir* is that he quotes all the chains of a narrative (*Insnad*) for every statement that he brings, and thus the authenticity of any narrative may be verified.

Criticism: He did not collect only authentic narrations, and thus it is difficult for a beginner to determine which narrations are authentic. In addition, at times *Tabari* quotes Judaeo-Christian narrations (*Isra'iliyat*) which are of no value whatsoever.

To rectify these short comings, the Tafsir was critically edited by one of the leading scholars of Hadith of this century, Shaykh Ahmad Shakir (d: 1377 AH), and is available in 30 volumes with his commentary on the Isnads of the narratives of the first few volumes. Unfortunately, Shakir passed away before his editing of the Hadith could be completed.

Tafsiru'l-Qur'an al-'Azim تفسير القرآن العظيم by *Ibn Kathir* This is generally regarded as the second most important *Tafsir* of the *Tafsir bi'l Riwayah* school. Its author *Ibn Kathir* (700-774 AH) was one of the most famous scholars of his time, having studied under *Ibn Taymiyyah* (d: 724 AH), *Hafiz Mizzi* (d. 742 AH) and other notable scholars. An advantage of this *Tafsir* is that it is easier to read than *Tabari's*, since *Ibn Kathir* summarizes to a great extent the difference of opinions that *Tabari* has quoted, usually only giving the strongest opinion. In addition, in many places *Ibn Kathir* gives his opinion, concerning the authenticity of a particular narration. At other times, however, he merely quotes the *Insnad*, and does not comment on the authenticity. Another advantage of this *Tafsir* is that he explains the verses in simple language, so that the reader may understand the intent of the verse. On occasions, he also mentions the various *Qira'at* of a verse, but he does not elaborate greatly on the grammar of the *Qur'an*.

The main criticism that had been made on this *Tafsir* is that *Ibn Kathir* occasionally quotes *Isra'iliyat* which are of absolutely no value. However, his view concerning the usefulness of these narratives is clear, for he writes after quoting one of these stories: '...and it seems that this story is taken from the *Isra'iliyat*, and therefore it is allowed to quote them, but not to believe in them or reject them. They cannot be relied upon except when they conform to the truth, and Allah knows best.'

In reality, this *Tafsir* is a very useful work for a student of the *Qur'an*, since it discusses and interprets the verses in sufficient detail to benefit from, without going into extreme details that might bore the reader.

Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay تفسير بالرأى

a. Definition

Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay, is not based directly on transmission of knowledge by the predecessors, but on the use of reason and intellect.

b. Advocates of *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay*

Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay does not mean 'interpretation by mere opinion', but deriving an opinion through *ijtihad* based on sound sources. It is permissible due to the following reasons:

Firstly, at many places in the *Qur'an*, believers are asked to ponder on the verses of the *Qur'an*: Do they not ponder on the *Qur'an*? Are their hearts bolted by their locks. (47:24)

Secondly, using one's reason is recommendable, when used in its proper place. It was approved by the Prophet (sws), eg. when he sent *Mu'adh Ibn Jabal* to Yemen.

Thirdly, we know that the Companions themselves would differ in the meaning of the *Qur'an*. This shows that they used their reason and intellect in this process.

c. Adversaries of *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay*

Some scholars declare *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay* as prohibited on the basis of the following *Hadith*:

- He who says [something] concerning the *Qur'an* on the basis of his opinion [alone] has taken his seat in the Fire.
- We have sent down to you [O Prophet] the message that you may explain clearly to people what has been sent to them. (16:44)

d. The Middle View

Tafsir Mahmud (praiseworthy) تفسير محمود, which is in agreement with the sources of *Tafsir*, the rules of *Shari'ah* and the Arabic language and is preferably used in areas where we do not have an explanation from the Prophet (sws). Furthermore, a person who undertakes *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay* should be well versed with the following disciplines:

1. *Lughat* (lexicography) لغت
2. *Nahaw* (Grammar) نحو
3. *Sarf* (Morphology) صرف
4. *Ishtaqqaq* (Inflections) اشتقاق
- 5- *Ma'ani, Bayan, Badi'* (Rhetoric) معنی، بیان، بدی
8. *Qira'at* (Science of Recital) قرات
9. *'Ilmu'l-Kalam* (Scholasticism) علم الکلام
10. *Usulu'l-Fiqh* (Principles of Jurisprudence) اصول الفقہ
11. *Asbabu'l Nuzul* (Reasons for a Revelation) اسباب النزول
12. *'Ilmu'l Qisas* (Knowledge of the Anecdotes) علم القصص
13. *Nasikh wa'l Mansukh* (Abrogation) ناسخ و المنسوخ
14. *Hadith* حدیث

Tafsir Madhmum (blameworthy) تفسير مذموم, which is done without proper knowledge of the sources of *Tafsir*, *Shari'ah* and the Arabic language. It is therefore based on mere opinion and must be rejected.

Important Works

Mafatihul-Ghayb مفتاح الغیب by Razi: The most famous *Tafsir* of the *Tafsir bi'l Ra'ay school* is that of *Fakhru'l-Din Razi* (544-606 AH) and became well known for his knowledge of Arabic grammar, and philosophy (*'ilmu'l-kalam*). *Mafatihul-Ghayb* (The Unlocking of the Knowledge of the Unseen), although apparently

seems to be complete, was completed after his death. Therefore, there is some difference of opinion as to who completed this work, and where he took over from *Razi*'s interpretation. Evidence seems to suggest that *Razi* was able to complete this work until *Surah Ambiya*, and after his death it was finished by two later scholars.¹⁹ Whatever the case may be, the work is still considered one of the classics. *Razi* was an ardent *Ash'ari* by faith, and a rigid follower of the *Shafi'i* school.

Therefore, he does not hesitate to defend his faith against the *Mu'tazilah* wherever he feels that a particular verse gives him the opportunity to do so. In verses of legal implications, he gives the positions of the different scholars, and invariably 'proves' the superiority and correctness of the *Shafi'i* point of view in every case.

One of the benefits that may be obtained from this *Tafsir* is that *Razi* includes a detailed discussion of the relationship between the various verses and *surahs* in the *Qur'an*, and this is a topic that is generally neglected in other *Tafsirs*. However, such relationships are, of course, based upon his personal opinion, and therefore cannot be accepted as absolute. Yet another benefit of this *Tafsir* is that he pays special attention to the grammatical analysis of the *Qur'an*.

The main criticism with regards to this *tafsir* is the fact that it is full of philosophical discussions and quotes from different philosophers, and in many places the work seems more like philosophical ramblings than *Qur'anic* commentary. In addition, he does not hesitate to quote the 'current scientific' opinions of his day, specifically whenever he interprets a verse dealing with astronomy and nature. Since the scientific views of the eleventh century are considered outdated to say the least, these discussions often seem rather ludicrous and far-fetched. Due to these discussions, many scholars have strongly criticised this *Tafsir*. *Abu Hayyan* (d. 745 AH) said of it: '*Imam Razi* brought in his *tafsir* many long discussion of topics that have absolutely no value to the science of *Tafsir*. This is why some scholars even said of it: 'In this *Tafsir* you will find everything except *Tafsir*!'

'Al-Kashshaf' الكشاف of *Zamakhshari*: Among the many *tafsirs* of the *Mu'tazilah*, the most famous one is *al-Kashaf an Haqa'iqu'l-Tanzil wa 'Uyuni'l-Aqawil fi Wujuhi'l-Ta'wil* (The Unveiling of the Truths of the Revelation and the Essence of the Opinions Concerning the Perspectives of Interpretation), by *Mahmud Ibn 'Umar al-Khawarizmi*, better known as *Zamakhshari* (467-538 AH). He was one of the leading *Mu'tazili* scholars of his time, and due to his great knowledge and eloquence, was able to spread the doctrines of the *Mu'tazilah* to a great extent. In reality, it is difficult to deny the *Kashaf* of its merits, and the praise that *Zamakhshari* heaped on it. Despite his blatant *Mu'tazili* bias, *Zamakhshari* was nonetheless a scholar of the highest calibre in terms of his knowledge of Arabic vocabulary, grammar and rhetoric. In his *Tafsir*, he emphasizes the grammatical beauty and eloquence of the *Qur'an*, and accentuates its literary style. He discusses the wisdom and beauty behind the particular phrasing of verses and passages, and demonstrates time and time again the literary magnificence and splendours of the *Qur'an*. Even subtle sentence structures that a less discerning eye would pass over are minutely scrutinised by him to unearth a panorama of meanings and wisdom that demonstrates over and over again the unrivalled literary miracle of the Book of Allah.

Since the *Tafsir* is based on the *Mu'tazali* doctrine, *Ibn Taymiyyah* (d: 724 AH), *Ibn Qayyim* (d: 758 AH), *Subki* (d: 756 AH) and many others have cautioned against it. However, due to the benefits of this *Tafsir*, certain later scholar of the *Ash'aris* tried to clear up the *Mu'tazili* doctrines of this *Tafsir* in critical footnotes. The most well-known of these commentaries is *al-Insa#f min al-Kashsha#f* by *Ahmad Ibn Muhammad Iskandari* (d: 683 AH).